"IN THE BEGINNING..."

GENESIS 29

IN 5 MINUTES

When:

- According to the timeline we've been using throughout this study, Jacob's journey to Haran occurred between 1760-1730 B.C.

Characters:

- Jacob – The son of Isaac and Rebekah and twin brother of Esau.
- Laban – The brother of Rebekah who lived in Haran.
- Leah – Laban's oldest daughter. She is described as having "weak" eyes.
- Rachel – The daughter of Laban. She was a shepherdess of her father's flocks in Haran. She is described as "beautiful in form and appearance."

Where:

- The events recorded in Genesis 29 took place in Haran, the homeland of Abraham's brother Nahor.

Outline:

- JACOB MEETS RACHEL AT A WELL (29:1-12):
    + After a long journey, Jacob stopped at a well of water near Haran.
    + Several shepherds were at the well waiting to water their sheep, and Jacob asked them if they knew Labon the son of Nahor.
    + They told him they knew him, and his daughter Rachel would be arriving at the well shortly, because she was a shepherdess of her father's flocks.
    + When Rachel arrived, Jacob watered her sheep and told her he was her father's kinsman.
- JACOB WORKS 7 YEARS FOR RACHEL (29:13-20):
    + Labon welcomed Jacob into his home, and he stayed a month.
    + Realizing Jacob intended to stay in Haran for some time, Laban asked him how he wanted to be paid for his work.
    + Jacob had fallen in love with Laban's youngest daughter, Rachel, and asked to serve Laban for 7 years in exchange for his daughter in marriage.
    + "So Jacob served seven years for Rachel, and they seemed to him but a few days because of the love he had for her" (29:20).
- LABAN DECEIVES JACOB ON HIS WEDDING DAY (29:21-30):
    + Laban prepared a feast for Jacob and Rachel's wedding.
    + But that evening, Laban sent his oldest daughter, Leah, to Jacob's bed chamber, rather than Rachel.
    + In the morning, Jacob realized what had happened and confronted Laban.
    + Laban told him it was not their custom to give the younger daughters in marriage before the eldest.
    + Jacob married Rachel a week later in exchange for 7 more years of service.
- JACOB'S CHILDREN WITH LEAH (29:31-35):
    + When God saw that Leah was loved less than Rachel, He blessed her with sons.
    + Leah bore Reuben, Simeon, Levi, and Judah.
    + Rachel was barren and couldn't have any children.

Application:

- The marriage customs in Genesis 29 probably seem strange to most western readers. They may seem unfair, uncivilized, or contrary to modern ideals.
- This chapter is a good reminder that cultures and customs have varied widely throughout history.
- Be careful not to read and interpret the Bible solely through your modern cultural perspective. Trying to interpret an ancient culture through your culture's lens is a sure way to so start misinterpreting things.
- To understand ancient people and their practices we need to remain open minded to the fact that not everyone in history shared our view of the way the world should work.